

children from a loveless marriage, and an aspiring writer. Shared artistic affinities soon deepened an instant emotional bond, and in 1835 the couple ran away to Geneva, Switzerland, where the first of their three children was born. Encouraged by Marie, Liszt read widely and began to compose his first major works; among these was a piano collection, *Album d'un voyageur*, inspired by the local Alpine scenery, later revised as the first “year” of the great cycle *Années de pèlerinage* (Years of Pilgrimage).



#### **PLAYING FOR FRANZ JOSEPH**

In this anonymous painting, Liszt is shown, in his later years, playing the piano for a charitable event. Emperor Franz Joseph and other members of the imperial family are seated before him.

Next year came an equally fruitful visit to Italy (early versions of the mighty Dante Sonata date from this period). The trip was interrupted by news of the flooding of the Danube valley in Hungary; suddenly identifying strongly with his Hungarian ancestry, Liszt gave a fundraising concert in Vienna, which marked the start of his career as a traveling virtuoso.